

Seeing Their Side Versus Feeling Their Pain: Differential Consequences of Perspective-Taking and Empathy at Work

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Perspective taking and empathic concern (empathy) have each been proposed as constructive approaches to social relationships. However, their potential distinctions, limitations, and consequences in task contexts are not well understood. We meta-analytically examined 304 independent samples to uncover unique effects of perspective taking and empathic concern on important work-related outcomes. We develop and test a contingency model of those effects, based on three facets of psychological interdependence: outcome, hierarchical (or power asymmetry), and social category (or in-group/out-group distinctions). Results revealed perspective taking and empathic concern to have positive impacts on being supportive of others, but the effects of empathic concern were stronger. In contrast, perspective taking was an asset and empathy was a liability for capturing value in strategic interactions (e.g., negotiations). Effects of perspective taking and empathic concern were differentially contingent on psychological interdependence. The impact of perspective taking, but not of empathic concern, was attenuated or reversed under negative outcome interdependence; perspective-taking leads to advantage taking in competitive contexts. Perspective taking was particularly beneficial when the actor had high power, but empathic concern's benefits were independent of hierarchy. Finally, social dissimilarity had no detectable impact on the effects of perspective taking or empathic concern, contrary to our theorizing. Overall results suggest two key conclusions. First, perspective taking and empathic concern have powerful effects on work-related outcomes. Second, each construct has its own distinctive and predictable impacts. We conclude by offering practical suggestions for improving workplace interactions through perspective taking and empathic concern.

Keywords: empathic concern, empathy, meta-analysis, perspective taking

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Few would disagree that managing social relationships is vital for being effective in modern organizations. The shift from manufacturing to knowledge- and service-based economies has resulted in work that is inherently interdependent and relational (Grant, 2007), and meta-analytic evidence underscores the impacts of social variables for focal actors' wellbeing, motivation, and performance at work (e.g., De Dreu, Weingart, & Kwon, 2000; Fang et al., 2015; Humphrey, Nahrgang, & Morgeson, 2007). On one hand, supportive interpersonal relationships play an important

role in vital sensemaking processes and employee flourishing (Colbert, Bono, & Purvanova, 2016; Grant, Dutton, & Rosso, 2008; Wrzesniewski, Dutton, & Debebe, 2003). At the same time, however, organizations are made up of people and situations with complex and mixed motives, and avoiding antagonism from co-workers can be even more important than receiving support (Chia-buru & Harrison, 2008; Duffy, Ganster, & Pagon, 2002).

What personal features can someone develop (rather than features that function as enduring individual differences) to foster those supportive but complex workplace relationships? Two promising solutions from social psychology represent ways that individuals might try to understand and connect with others. *Perspective taking* is a cognitive attempt to consider another's viewpoint. *Empathic concern* (or simply, "empathy"¹) is an emotional response to another's hardship (Davis, 1980). Perspective taking and empathic concern are often touted as trainable and mutable orientations that might improve joint outcomes at work (Gilin, Maddux, Carpenter, & Galinsky, 2013). More than 30 years of empirical research suggests their possible advantages for navigating social interactions involved in task perfor-

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¹ In the literature, the term "empathy" sometimes refers to a broader set of processes which includes empathic concern (see Batson, 2011). We use it throughout the paper as a shorthand for empathic concern, although we want to be clear that our theory and data focus specifically on the experience of empathic concern for a target as defined here.

mance (for narrative reviews, see Ku, Wang, & Galinsky, 2015; Parker, Atkins, & Axtell, 2008).

Overall, perspective taking and empathic concern have been considered highly overlapping constructs with parallel routes to the same positive social outcomes, both at work and more broadly (Vorauer, 2013). However, relatively recent empirical evidence has begun to uncover possible divergent effects. In a series of experiments, perspective taking provided advantages for both integrative and distributive negotiation outcomes, whereas empathic concern had either nominal or relatively harmful impacts at the bargaining table (Galinsky, Maddux, Gilin, & White, 2008). These findings have led researchers to suggest that perspective taking may be better suited for some tasks or contexts than empathic concern, and vice versa (Galinsky, Gilin, & Maddux, 2011; Gilin et al., 2013). Still, the underlying mechanisms that drive divergent effects under some conditions, and parallel outcomes in others, are not well understood.

In addition, perspective taking and empathic concern may each have a “dark side.” Potentially key distinctions in their adverse outcomes further suggest differences in their underlying mechanisms. Perspective taking appears to nudge individuals toward Machiavellian behavior in some circumstances (Epley, Caruso, & Bazerman, 2006), whereas empathic concern for one particular social target can impede fair outcomes for others overall (Batson, Klein, Highberger, & Shaw, 1995; Blader & Rothman, 2014). The precise conditions under which such negative effects for focal individuals (actors) and their interaction partners (targets) might emerge are not clearly established.

Are perspective taking and empathic concern substitutable constructs, or do they have distinct mechanisms that drive unique outcomes? Are they routinely helpful, or are some situations especially well-suited to feelings of empathy for a coworker, but not for understanding his or her perspective, and vice versa? Can attempts at perspective taking or empathic concern backfire in unexpected ways, and if so, when? Despite the breadth, volume, and supportive tone of literature investigating the effects of perspective taking and empathic concern, these specific questions remain unresolved.

The main purpose of the present paper is to answer these questions. We do so by meta-analytically summarizing the literature on how perspective taking and empathic concern operate in relationally embedded work. First, we construct a model in which we hypothesize relative and, at times, diverging direct effects based on theoretically distinct mechanisms for the effects of perspective taking and empathic concern. Next, we identify and examine three aspects of *psychological interdependence*—stemming from (a) outcome distributions, (b) status hierarchies, or (c) social categorizations—that may qualify the effects of perspective taking and empathic concern. Finally, our model predicts the potential downsides associated with both perspective taking and empathic concern in tasks with complex psychological interdependencies.

In sum, we contribute to applied psychological theory by proposing and testing a *contingency framework of both the unique and relative impacts of perspective taking and empathic concern at work*. Figure 1 depicts this framework. Distinct patterns (in terms of sign and strength) of perspective taking and empathic concern’s effects on three key outcomes (Hypotheses 2–9 below) further diverge under three contingencies of psychological interdependence (Hypotheses 10–14). Those distinct patterns are premised on the idea that perspective taking and empathic concern are separable (Hypothesis 1), which we turn to first.

Perspective Taking and Empathic Concern: Substitutes or Separates?

Streams of prior work have often treated perspective taking and empathic concern as essentially interchangeable constructs. For example, some existing measures and manipulations explicitly capture both cognitive *and* emotional aspects of trying to understand targets. It is not uncommon for measures of perspective taking to include items that explicitly tap actors’ feelings of empathic concern for targets (Axtell, Parker, Holman, & Totterdell, 2007; Calvard, 2010; Gregory, Moates, & Gregory, 2011; Mor, Morris, & Joh, 2013; Parker & Axtell, 2001). In addition, a typical method for manipulating perspective taking experimentally has been shown to induce feelings of empathy for the target, but authors have not suggested that such contamination is problematic (Galinsky & Moskowitz, 2000). Construct labels and definitions in the literature have also tended to blend or switch elements of perspective taking and empathic concern, describing perspective taking as the “cognitive form of empathy” (Ho & Gupta, 2012, p. 434) and empathic concern as a “more affective form of perspective taking” (Vorauer, Martens, & Sasaki, 2009, p. 813). This ambivalence in the literature implies largely substitutable rather than crucially distinct or separate constructs.

Implications of construct substitutability have led researchers to hypothesize and find general similarities in the consequences of perspective taking and empathic concern. Both “seeing their side” and “feeling their pain” can be seen as ways of trying to understand the internal thoughts and experiences of others. Whether the route is largely cognitive (perspective taking), or affective (empathic concern), each *can* facilitate positive social interactions and relationships in interdependent tasks. Scholars in multiple disciplines have asserted that perspective taking can promote beneficial actor-target interactions in task contexts (Galinsky, Ku, & Wang, 2005; Ku et al., 2015; Parker et al., 2008). Similarly, empathic concern can promote prosocial work behavior (Coke, Batson, & McDavis, 1978; Settoon & Mossholder, 2002). Because of similarities in how the extant literature has discussed both the constructs and their outcomes, a reasonable conclusion might be that perspective taking and empathic concern are mostly overlapping, spurring the same processes to help actors understand targets at work.

However, we argue that the literature’s notions of construct and outcome similarity have, to date, largely concealed separate mechanisms and different outcomes. Perspective taking and empathic concern may indeed co-occur, but experimental evidence has revealed that each can also occur independently (Batson, 2011). Moreover, we argue that their outflows into social relationships are distinguishable from one another—beyond noting that one is largely cognitive and the other is largely affective. Key theoretical differences between perspective taking and empathic concern (summarized in Table 1) drive our hypotheses for unique patterns of effects in organizations. In addition, these distinctions (elaborated below) motivate our first hypothesis, which formally proposes the distinction between perspective taking and empathy.

Hypothesis 1: Perspective taking and empathy are distinct, but positively correlated constructs.

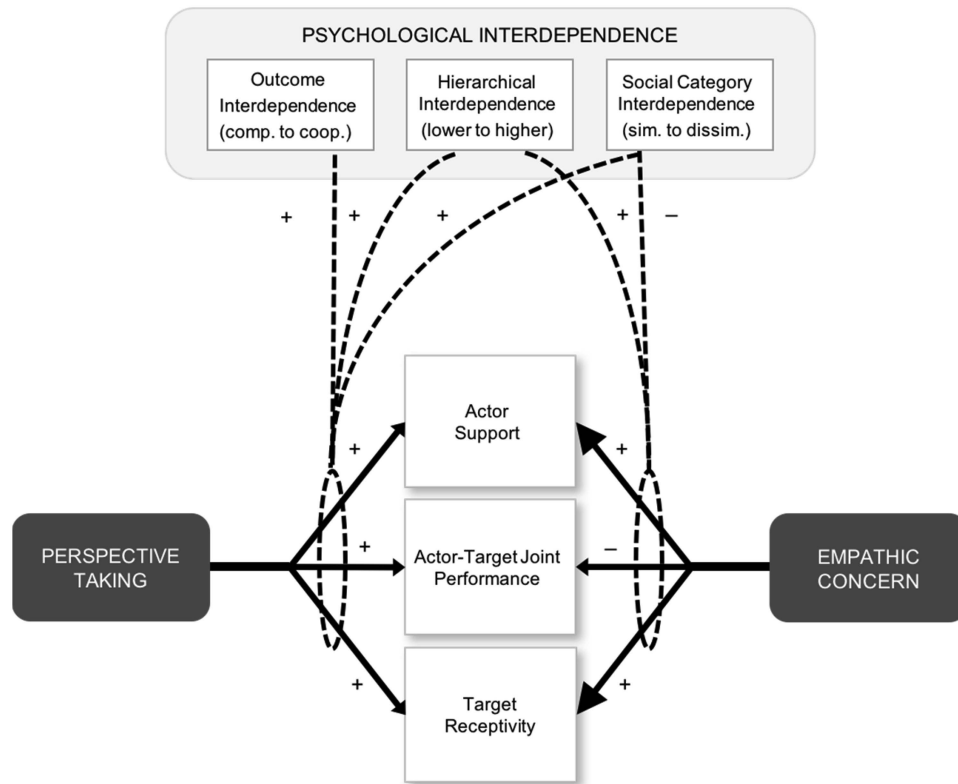


Figure 1. Contingency model of the effects of perspective taking and empathic concern. Larger arrows represent hypotheses for relatively stronger effects of empathic concern versus perspective taking.

Why Should It Matter? Implications for Differential Effects

As perspective taking and empathic concern are often studied together (Parker et al., 2008), it is not clear initially how their differential content and mechanisms make one or the other more potent for specific outcomes at work. Delineating potential differences in the effects of perspective taking and empathic concern has important practical and empirical implications. If one construct has consistently stronger positive impacts on desired workplace consequences, focusing on the other may result in suboptimal effects. In addition, if effects of one are positive and the other are negative, training or inducing both indiscriminately could be ineffective, as their impacts cancel one

another out. Viewing perspective taking and empathic concern through the lens of their separate mechanisms predicates differential, and potentially divergent outcomes for actors and targets engaging in interdependent tasks. Therefore, in the following sections, we develop hypotheses regarding their unique effects on three key work-related outcomes: *actor support*, *actor-target joint performance*, and *target receptivity*. These relationships are also depicted in the lower half of Figure 1.

Actor Support

To begin, we wanted to capture the types of outcomes that indicate an actor's desire, willingness, or attempt to cultivate a bond with or

Table 1

Theoretical Differentiation Between Perspective Taking and Empathic Concern Constructs

Measure	Perspective taking	Empathic concern
Systematic biases	Actor (ego)-centric information processing: graduated evaluation of plausible alternative perspectives <i>anchoring</i> on ego, resulting in perceptions biased toward the actor's perspective	Target (alter)-centric emotion processing: <i>amplification</i> of target's experience, resulting in perceptions biased toward the target's perceived need
Social function	Motivating and "mentalizing": actors ascribe goals and intentions to targets, along with motivation to act	Motivating
Focus of attention	Dual: actors hold both self- and target's interests in mind	Singular: actors focus on target's interests
Potential contingencies	Outcome interdependence Hierarchical/power interdependence Social category interdependence	Hierarchical/power interdependence Social category interdependence

provide social resources to a target, which we term actor support. Is perspective taking or empathic concern more important for fostering an actor's supportive *attitudes* and *intentions* toward targets in task environments? Few authors have compared the impacts of both constructs in the same investigation, and empirical evidence is inconclusive. For example, Wang and colleagues (2014) found that perspective taking reduced stereotypical attitudes toward those in stigmatized professions, whereas empathic concern did not. Similarly, perspective taking predicted willingness to engage with members of an out-group over and above empathic concern (Wang, Ku, Tai, & Galinsky, 2014). In another investigation, empathic concern and perspective taking were roughly similar in their inverse association with the propensity to morally disengage at work (Moore, Detert, Klebe Treviño, Baker, & Mayer, 2012). Conversely, empathic concern had a stronger effect than perspective taking on the disapproval of both unethical negotiation tactics (T. Cohen, 2010) and sexual harassment in the workplace (Diehl, Glaser, & Bohner, 2014).

Empirical evidence examining the relative effects of perspective taking and empathic concern on supportive *behavior* toward others at work is also mixed. Perspective taking was a slightly stronger predictor than empathic concern of making ethically sound recommendations to employees in a HR context (Mencel & May, 2009). On the other hand, some have found that empathic concern has a relatively stronger impact than perspective taking in reducing workplace bullying behavior (Jacobson, Hood, & Jacobson, 2015). Others have found roughly similar effects for perspective taking and empathic concern on OCBs (Bettencourt, Gwinner, & Meuter, 2001; T. Cohen, Panter, Turan, Morse, & Kim, 2014). In addition, both perspective taking and empathic concern have been linked to quality of medical care (Riggio & Taylor, 2000; Wright, McKendree, Morgan, Allgar, & Brown, 2014). Thus, although the literature has established that both perspective taking and empathy can promote supportive attitudes, intentions, and behaviors (Ku et al., 2015), it is unclear whether one is more important for facilitating such outcomes.

Actor- versus target-centric biases. By turning to the unique mechanisms of perspective taking and empathic concern, we might inform ideas about their relative utility in predicting supportive attitudes and behavior toward others at work. One key basis for viewing perspective taking and empathic concern as separates, not substitutes, lies in the nature of their (systematic) inaccuracies. Although both are means by which an actor might try to gain a better understanding of the thoughts, motives, needs, and values of a target, it is not presumed that they do so with high fidelity. Emotions of empathic concern do not have to match the target's, differentiating this construct from processes such as mirroring and emotional contagion (Batson, 2011). Similarly, we agree with scholars who conceptualize perspective taking as agnostic with respect to accuracy (Ku et al., 2015). Both perspective taking and empathic concern provide information to the actor that supports the actor's conclusion about the target's inner experiences, but these conclusions may be biased in systematic ways.

Perspective taking is a cognitive process that tends to result in actor-centrally biased perceptions of the target's perspective. Specifically, evidence suggests that attempts to take the perspective of a target involve sequential considerations, with the actor anchoring on his or her *own* perspective and moving gradually closer to what the target could be thinking (Epley, Keysar, Van Boven, & Gilovich, 2004). This process of anchoring and adjustment is insufficient (Tversky & Kahneman, 1974), as the actor tends to settle on the first perspective that plausibly could be applied to the target (Epley &

Gilovich, 2006), which is apparent in the finding that actors who hold negative self-views evaluate targets less positively (Galinsky & Ku, 2004). So, perspective-taking facilitates an increased self-other overlap between actor and target (Galinsky et al., 2005), but actors might also tend to underestimate the uniqueness of targets' values, needs, and desires relative to their own.

In contrast, the mechanism of empathic concern may lead to target-centric biases for two reasons. First, feeling empathic emotions toward the target informs the actor that he or she values the target's needs and desires (Batson, Engel, & Fridell, 1999; Batson, Turk, Shaw, & Klein, 1995). Second, emotions have a physiological arousal component, which further amplifies the intensity with which the actor comes to value the target's welfare (see Tomkins, 1962). Thus, the experience that empathic concern provides to the actor, along with its amplification, leads to an overemphasis on the care and attention directed toward the target's perceived needs, desires, and/or experiences. We suggest, then, that while "seeing their side" might not allow actors to reach far enough from themselves to fully support the target's unique needs, "feeling their pain" might direct excessive effort or attention toward such a goal (as indicated by the heavier arrow flowing from empathic concern, relative to perspective taking, to actor support in Figure 1)

Hypothesis 2: Perspective taking is positively related to an actor's supportive (a) attitudes, (b) intentions, and (c) behavior toward targets.

Hypothesis 3: Empathic concern is positively related to an actor's supportive (a) attitudes, (b) intentions, and (c) behavior toward targets target.

Hypothesis 4: Empathic concern has a stronger relationship than perspective taking to an actor's supportive (a) attitudes, (b) intentions, and (c) behavior toward targets target.

Actor-Target Joint Performance

Effects of perspective taking and empathic concern on performance in jointly determined tasks have been examined mainly in the context of negotiations or strategic interactions. Scholars have proposed and found that perspective taking results in the capture of greater value for actors by increasing concessionary movement from opponents (Neale & Bazerman, 1983) and reducing the anchoring bias of an opponent's first offer (Galinsky & Mussweiler, 2001). In addition, perspective taking in negotiations is thought to facilitate integrative outcomes such as reaching a deal and increasing joint gain (Galinsky, Maddux, et al., 2008), because seeing overlap with a target's interests increases the likelihood of turn-taking strategies such as logrolling (Trötschel, Hüffmeier, Loschelder, Schwartz, & Gollwitzer, 2011). Perspective taking has also been shown to benefit actor-target joint performance in other types of interdependent tasks, such as shared decision making (Galinsky, Magee, Rus, Rothman, & Todd, 2014) and problem solving (Grant & Berry, 2011; Hoever, van Knippenberg, van Ginkel, & Barkema, 2012).

The implications of empathic concern for joint task performance, on the other hand, are less clear. Researchers have found limited benefits to actors' negotiation outcomes when exercising empathic concern for one's counterpart (Galinsky, Maddux, et al., 2008), leading to the conclusion that any advantages conferred by empathic concern in strategic interactions operate through trust- or

relationship-building mechanisms (Gilin et al., 2013). In addition, evidence is limited regarding empathic concern's performance effects in task domains beyond negotiations, leaving a murky picture of how these effects may or may not diverge from perspective taking. We instead apply what is theorized about differences in perspective taking and empathic concern to bolster our prediction for distinct effects on joint outcomes.

Motivation and "mentalization." In alignment with the above hypothesized relationships, both perspective taking and empathic concern can foster more positive interactions and relationships with targets. This occurs through their motivational function. For example, when interacting with coworkers outside of one's unit, an actor who considers those external perspectives gains insight into their intentions and desires by attributing self-referent information. When these attributions are positive, the actor will be more motivated to respond in kind to cross-unit coworkers with supportive and cooperative behaviors (Parker & Axtell, 2001). The information provided by empathic emotion (that an actor values the target's welfare) can also motivate an actor to react to targets' perceived needs with attempts to help (Coke et al., 1978). In the context of caregiving professions, for example, empathic concern underscores the target's need and the actor's opportunity to extend care, making it a key motivating factor for displaying compassion to patients (Dutton, Workman, & Hardin, 2014). Although the basis differs, both perspective taking and empathic concern function as motivational tools for eliciting (often, supportive) actions when working interdependently with targets.

In addition, perspective taking has a second function, making it perhaps a more robust tool than empathic concern for navigating complexities of jointly determined social landscapes at work. Perspective taking involves the "mentalization" of others, or ascribing goals and intentions to targets, whereas empathic concern simply draws an actor's focus to the emotional state of targets (Singer, 2006, p. 856). As a result, perspective takers can use this information to anticipate the target's interests, as well as the likely consequences of alternative actions toward the target (Williams, 2007). This information could be used to better support the target, but it is likely this same cognitive elaboration process that provides advantages to perspective takers, but not empathizers, in negotiation tasks (Galinsky, Maddux, et al., 2008). In other words, emotions of empathic concern in response to the target's perceived experiences motivate the actor to move toward the needs of the target, but perspective taking can either motivate the actor to move toward, or to *navigate around* those desires or needs.

Singular or dual focus of attention. In addition, scholars have suggested that perspective taking is more advantageous than empathic concern for performance in strategic tasks due to differences in their direction of attention (Galinsky et al., 2011). Despite its ego-centric bias, perspective taking allows actors to hold both self- and other-interests in mind when interacting with targets. Empathic concern, on the other hand, magnifies the interests of the target, which may result in actors sacrificing their own self-interests or reaching suboptimal overall outcomes. In mixed-motive interactions, capturing value requires an actor to hold self-interests in focus, but empathic concern draws attention toward the interests of a target. It is clear then, why perspective taking allows actors to accrue value and maximize joint gain in negotiations, while empathic concern does not. Indeed, empathic concern can lead to conciliatory behavior toward the target that harms one's own welfare (Batson & Ahmad, 2001) or creates unfair

distributions that deprive nontarget group members of valued resources (Batson, Batson, et al., 1995; Batson, Klein, et al., 1995).

Moreover, scholars have underscored the broader point that mixed-motive considerations are pervasive throughout everyday organizational decisions and tasks (De Dreu & Nauta, 2009). For example, choosing to stop and help a teammate with a task may indirectly harm others or sacrifice one's own productivity (Bolino & Grant, 2016). Thus, the ability of perspective-takers to hold self- and other-interests in balance with one another should provide performance advantages in the larger context of interdependent tasks. In contrast, empathy's myopic focus on the target may impede the actor's own performance, and directing resources (both material and social) disproportionately to the target may harm the common good. Accordingly, we hypothesize that the negative effect of empathy will diverge from the advantages of perspective taking on jointly determined performance outcomes (Galinsky, Maddux, et al., 2008; Gilin et al., 2013).

Hypothesis 5: Perspective taking is positively related to both (a) an actor's individual performance and (b) integrative performance in joint tasks with targets.

Hypothesis 6: Empathic concern is negatively related to both (a) an actor's individual performance and (b) integrative performance in joint tasks with targets.

Target Receptivity

On the receiving end, it is important to understand how intended targets of perspective taking and empathic concern might react to overtures from actors. Targets might feel more satisfied with their interactions with the actor, and, in turn, choose to react in ways that further support working relationships with the actor. These outcomes we term *target receptivity*. Although a nascent area of inquiry, evidence suggests that a target sensing his or her own perspective has been taken can reciprocate consequences to the actor, including increased liking and pro-social behavior (Goldstein, Vezich, & Shapiro, 2014). It is also reasonable to infer that targets will respond positively to the supportive attitudes and behaviors from perspective-taking actors, and preliminary evidence supports this supposition (Vorauer & Quesnel, 2016). Finally, research suggests that when targets' perspectives are taken, they respond positively by offering more unique information to the actor (Galinsky et al., 2014) and expending more effort on joint tasks (Skinner & Spurgeon, 2005).

Similarly, receiving empathic concern from an actor may elicit positive attitudinal and behavioral responses from targets. Targets who receive empathic concern are more likely to feel understood by focal actors (Hodges, Kiel, Kramer, Veach, & Villanueva, 2010), and feeling known by coworkers and managers may in turn strengthen commitment to the organization (Wiesenfeld, Swann, Brockner, & Bartel, 2007). Because empathic concern often stirs up motivation to improve the welfare of the target (Batson, 2011), receivers of empathic concern may also benefit from psychosocial resources provided by the actor's expressions of care (Lilius, 2012). For example, research has shown that manager empathy can improve employee well-being (Scott, Colquitt, Paddock, & Judge, 2010). Finally, researchers have suggested that empathic concern or compassion can lead to generative processes that foster longer-term cooperation and collaboration at work (Dutton, Lilius, & Kanov, 2007).

Do targets prefer that actors try to see their side, or would they rather know that others try to feel their pain? Based in part on the

differential mechanisms outlined above, we expect targets to respond more positively to empathic concern than to perspective taking from actors. Because empathic concern is more likely to result in action favoring the target's experiences, rather than action with an ego-centric bias (as with perspective taking), targets likely experience more positive emotions in interactions with empathic actors. In addition, empathic concern is thought to build relational trust (Brooks, Dai, & Schweitzer, 2014; Dutton et al., 2007), whereas perspective taking has the potential to lead to deception when it is strategically advantageous for the actor (Pierce, Kilduff, Galinsky, & Sivanathan, 2013). Although few have directly investigated the relative effects of perspective taking and empathic concern on target attitudes and behaviors (and none, to our knowledge, on target intentions), preliminary evidence supports preferences for empathic partners (e.g., Galinsky, Maddux, et al., 2008). As such, Figure 1 depicts a relatively heavier arrow from empathic concern to target receptivity, compared to the one from perspective taking to target receptivity.

Hypothesis 7: An actor's perspective taking is positively related to a target's receptive (a) attitudes and (b) behavior.

Hypothesis 8: An actor's empathic concern is positively related to a target's positive receptive (a) attitudes and (b) behavior.

Hypothesis 9: An actor's empathic concern has a stronger relationship than perspective taking to a target's receptive (a) attitudes and (b) behavior.

A Contingent View: Moderation by Psychological Interdependence

In addition to differences in the direct effects of perspective taking and empathic concern, their mechanisms might further diverge based on certain forms of psychological interdependence (Deutsch, 1982) between actor and target. Interdependence theory predicts social outcomes based on the individual or joint (coordinated) determination of goals and rewards (Kelley & Thibaut, 1978). Different sources of psychological interdependence correspond to key differences in how workplace actors cognitively and motivationally orient themselves to interactions with targets, and thus act as contextual filters in the process of seeing another's side or feeling their pain. Building on this notion, we hypothesize that the effects of perspective taking and empathic concern may interact with three types of actor-target interdependencies—those stemming from outcomes, hierarchies, and social categorizations—in distinct ways. These contingencies are visually depicted by the dotted lines in Figure 1.

Outcome Interdependence

As organizational actors work more closely with one another on complex tasks, it is important to consider the impact of their *outcome interdependence*: the degree to which rewards depend on the performance of the collective or of the actor-partner combination, rather than solely on one's own efforts (Wageman, 1995). Positive (i.e., "cooperative") outcome interdependence leads to the belief that the performance of others facilitates goal achievement for oneself. Negative outcome interdependence (i.e., "competitive" or "zero-sum" situations) is experienced when the performance of

another impedes rewards for oneself (De Dreu, 2010; Kelley & Thibaut, 1978). Competition orients the actor toward aggressive and self-protective motivations (Deutsch, 1982), and research has shown that anticipating personal gains or losses of scarce resources from negative outcome interdependence raises the likelihood of engaging in self-serving behavior at work (Johns, 1999).

The direction of outcome interdependence between the actor and target may flip effects of perspective taking from positive to negative, or from giving to getting, for two reasons. First, the tendency in perspective taking toward actor-centric biases may cause the actor to overestimate the extent to which targets are similarly competitively oriented toward them, eroding trust. Second, perspective-taking's dual focus of attention allows actors to balance both self- and other-interests, but negative outcome interdependence may amplify the former. As a result, preserving or accruing more of one's own resources likely takes precedence over providing support to the target. Value capture might be enhanced, perhaps even at the expense of value creation, when the possibility of rewards heightens the significance of perspective taking's "mentalization" function. In other words, as perspective takers anticipate targets' next moves by imagining their competitive goals or intentions, that information can be used to navigate around the target to the actor's strategic advantage. Perspective taking can lead to advantage taking.

Research has shown that in competitive negotiations, perspective-taking actors may be more willing to deceive the target by engaging in unethical tactics (Pierce et al., 2013), but perform better overall on value capture (Trötschel et al., 2011). When making decisions regarding the allocation of resources, perspective-taking actors seized more for themselves merely when told that (rather than having objectively experienced that) outcomes were competitive rather than cooperative, even when it hurt their group's collective performance (Epley et al., 2006). Although perspective taking is an other-oriented process, it coexists with self-interest in such a way that amplifies divergent motives between actor and target in competitive contexts. Thus, it enhances the actor's desire to exploit, or an imperative to protect against manipulation by, a target for the sake of one's own reward (Ku et al., 2015).

In contrast, we do not expect effects of empathic concern to be changed by perceptions of positive or negative outcome interdependence between actor and target (Galinsky, Maddux, et al., 2008; Ku et al., 2015). Unlike perspective taking, empathic concern errs toward target-centric biases, focusing attention on the target's needs and desires. Rather than providing information the actor can use to circumvent the target, empathic concern cultivates the motivation to help.

Indeed, evidence suggests that empathic concern can dampen the self-concern often prompted by competitive contexts; that is, empathic concern's impact is resistant to a distributive payoff structure. For example, when empathy was induced in participants in a prisoner's dilemma task, individuals were more likely than controls to protect (not defect from) the other party, even knowing that the other party had already defected (Batson & Ahmad, 2001). In addition, empathic concern's affective mechanism may sidestep the cognitive complexity needed to navigate mixed motive interactions or negotiations, resulting in the actor settling on suboptimal integrative ("expand the pie") solutions (Galinsky, Maddux, et al., 2008). Thus, outcome interdependence pulls perspective taking

effects in the (positive or negative) direction of the interdependence, while leaving the effects of empathic concern unmoved.

Hypothesis 10: Outcome interdependencies between actor and target moderate the effect of perspective taking, such that its positive effect is weakened in competitive contexts (when outcome interdependence is negative), and strengthened in cooperative contexts.

Asymmetric Power or Hierarchical Interdependence

Turning to another form of interdependence, we predict how perspective taking and empathic concern may be moderated differently by power asymmetry or hierarchical differentiations between actor and target. Although powerful people may be less likely to take the perspective of others (Galinsky, Magee, Inesi, & Gruenfeld, 2006), research suggests added benefits of perspective taking when they do (Galinsky et al., 2014). Power spurs individuals to action (Galinsky, Gruenfeld, & Magee, 2003); perspective taking directs this power toward achieving salient goals. Powerful versus less powerful perspective-takers also engaged in greater interactional justice with and elicited more critical information from targets (Galinsky et al., 2014). Thus, we expect that actor-target hierarchy gradients will amplify positive effects of perspective taking for actors in support of the target.

We expect that, as with perspective taking, a hierarchy gradient between actor and target might also strengthen the positive effects of empathic concern. However, there is a different underlying mechanism. Perceiving that the target of empathic concern is disadvantaged in the hierarchy promotes the actor's altruistic motivation (Zahn-Waxler & Radke-Yarrow, 1990). According to the empathy-altruism hypothesis, the actor feels the need to act in a way that increases the welfare of the target (Batson, 2011). We therefore propose that an actor higher in status or power compared (downward) to the target is more likely to feel the need to help the target as someone in a position of relative vulnerability. Alternatively, an actor lower on the hierarchy gradient relative to the target should feel less compelled to act altruistically on behalf of someone (upward) who ostensibly has greater control of valued resources than oneself. Thus, the similar moderating effect of power asymmetries on perspective taking and empathic concern should preserve relative differences between their direct effects hypothesized above.

Hypothesis 11: Hierarchical interdependencies between actor and target moderate the effect of perspective taking, such that the effect is stronger when the actor has relatively more status or power than the target, and weaker when the actor has relatively less status or power than the target.

Hypothesis 12: Hierarchical interdependencies between actor and target moderate the effect of empathic concern, such that the effect is stronger when the actor has relatively more status or power than the target, and weaker when the actor has relatively less status or power than the target.

Social Category Interdependence

Social group categorization can be conceptualized as another source of interdependency, in that it binds together those in the

same category, but divides actors and targets who breach membership across categories (Tajfel, 2010). Actors may categorize targets based on observable demographics, including racial, ethnic, or gender attributes, but social (dis)similarity can also be experienced through the salience of any in-group versus out-group classification, such as membership in different teams, departments, or organizations (Carton & Cummings, 2013). Identification with one's in-group forms the basis of interdependency though shared interests with other in-group members (De Dreu, 2010). The organizational difficulties thought to be associated with in-group/out-group categorizations have been well-documented; they are a fundamental source of dysfunction in dyads and teams at work (Ashforth, Rogers, & Corley, 2011; Hogg & Terry, 2000; Ren, Gray, & Harrison, 2014). Both perspective taking and empathic concern have been suggested as tools for counteracting the negative effects of such social categorization, including stereotyping and prejudice toward outgroup members (Batson et al., 1997; Todd, Galinsky, & Bodenhausen, 2012).

We argue that perspective taking will have a greater effect on support for targets who are socially dissimilar, but these dissimilarities may weaken the effects of empathic concern. Construal-level theory would posit that the greater social distance an actor is from a target, the more likely the target is to be represented in the mind of the actor by high-level essentials or features stereotypical of that social group (Wiesenfeld, Reyt, Brockner, & Trope, 2017). As a tool for bridging differences in one's mental representations of self and other (Galinsky & Moskowitz, 2000), perspective taking should be particularly powerful when it allows actors to span the distances between social groupings. In addition, perspective takers are likely to experience a greater increase in interdependency when considering targets who were initially seen as socially distant, as opposed to in-group targets with whom interests were already aligned.

However, feeling empathic concern for a socially dissimilar target may weaken its effects. Most workplace interactions tend to be driven by norms of equity and reciprocal exchange (Adams, 1965; Cropanzano & Mitchell, 2005). Collectives experiencing a sense of shared identity, however, are more likely to follow communal norms, where help and resources are directed toward those in immediate need rather than those who are deemed most deserving or able to reciprocate (Clark & Mills, 2011; Flynn, 2005). Feeling empathic concern in conjunction with a strong sense of shared identity, then, may amplify communal values and need-based support. On the other hand, empathic concern for those outside of the ingroup may amplify equity values and merit-based support. As such, empathic concern should have a disproportionately stronger positive impact on socially similar targets, relative to dissimilar targets. These proposed differences further contribute to our case for perspective taking and empathic concern as meaningfully distinct.

Hypothesis 13: Social group interdependencies between actor and target moderate the effect of perspective taking, such that the effect is stronger when the actor and target are separated by social dissimilarity.

Hypothesis 14: Social group interdependencies between actor and target moderate the effect of empathic concern, such that the effect is weaker when the actor and target are separated by social dissimilarity.

Method

Literature Search and Inclusion Criteria

Our sample of investigations and effect sizes was gathered from a variety of sources. First, the search terms *perspective taking*, *empathic concern*, and multiple synonyms (empathy, sympathy, compassion, cognitive empathy, mind-reading) were entered into the online databases of Web of Science, ERIC, SSRN, and Google Scholar, as well as the Academy of Management Publications search page (which included *Proceedings* for the Academy of Management Annual Meetings). We also employed several field-specific key words (*management*, *organizational*, *team*, or *task*) to identify relevant investigations in the organizational behavior and applied psychology literatures. Second, we sourced references to seminal articles (Batson, Batson, et al., 1995; Galinsky & Moskowitz, 2000; Galinsky & Mussweiler, 2001; Parker & Axtell, 2001) and narrative reviews (Batson et al., 2003; Kleinlogel & Dietz, 2014; Ku et al., 2015; Parker et al., 2008) on perspective taking and empathic concern in organizations. Third, we supplemented these lists by searching for articles citing key measures (e.g., Davis, 1980; Parker & Axtell, 2001) and experimental manipulations (e.g., Galinsky & Moskowitz, 2000; Galinsky & Mussweiler, 2001) for empathy and perspective taking. Finally, to address the “file drawer problem” and potential publication bias, we contacted authors of conference presentations and we posted advertisements for effect sizes from unpublished data on various applied psychology and organizational behavior message boards and listservs.

Investigations were included if they examined effects of perspective taking or empathic concern in an organizationally relevant or interdependent task context. That is, nonemployee samples were included only when study participants (i.e., actors) were working together with another or multiple others (i.e., targets) toward some broader aim. Studies of romantic, intimate, or familial relationships, as well as those examining perspective taking and empathic concern in children and teens, were excluded from our analysis. To compute effect sizes and conduct independent analyses, we ensured that studies reported quantitative data about the relationships in question and used a nonoverlapping sample (e.g., data presented at conferences were not included when resulting publications reported data from the same sample). Finally, because we were interested in identifying effects of individual-level antecedents on interpersonal outcomes, a handful of studies examining perspective taking or empathic concern at the dyadic and group-level were excluded. After applying these inclusion and exclusion criteria, the final sample comprised 118 investigations (18 unpublished) reporting effect sizes for 304 independent samples (49 unpublished).

Coding Schemes

Independent constructs. Studies in the resulting sample were coded for a number of criteria. First, we determined whether the independent construct was operationalized as perspective taking or empathic concern, according to the definitions above. Studies of perspective taking that actually mea-

sured or manipulated empathic concern, and vice versa, were relabeled to reflect the construct that was captured. In addition, some studies could be more accurately classified as operationalizing a blend of perspective taking and empathic concern. These investigations measured both cognitive and affective orientations toward the target (Parker & Axtell, 2001), or instructed participants to consider the target’s viewpoint *and* to try to feel what he or she was feeling (e.g., Patient & Skarlicki, 2010 Study 2). These studies were given a distinct code, and we set them aside for post hoc analysis. Agreement in coding for the independent construct was 93%, and discrepancies were resolved through a discussion between the first author and a trained but independent coder. This resolution strategy was used for all of the coded variables described below.

Dependent constructs. Dependent constructs were categorized into outcome domains designated in our hypothesis development. *Actor support* outcomes included *attitudes* (e.g., liking, trust, disapproval of unethical treatment, concerns to be fair, desire for future contact), *intentions* (e.g., to volunteer, to help), or *behaviors* toward the target (e.g., sharing task information, helping, providing resources, cooperating). *Actor-target joint performance* included *value capture* (or, more generally, accrual of resources to the actor) and *value creation*, which also included integrative outcomes such as reaching an agreement, joint decision quality, or combined output. The final set of outcomes, *target receptivity*, pertained to changes in the target’s own *attitudes* (e.g., satisfaction with the interaction) or *behaviors* (e.g., exerting extra effort). Interrater agreement for the outcome codes was also 93%.

Moderators and controls. Original studies were coded for each of the three forms of psychological interdependence we hypothesized as moderators. *Outcome interdependence* was operationalized using Wageman’s (1995) definition noted above. Studies received a code of -1 for negative outcome interdependence (e.g., competition; distributive negotiation contexts); 0 for none (e.g., undifferentiated coworker interactions); or 1 for positive outcome interdependence (e.g., joint decision-making tasks, integrative negotiations). Because strategic interactions can rarely be classified as purely negative or purely positive outcome interdependence, and are often mixed-motive in some way (De Dreu, 2010), our coding was based on whether contexts or scenarios presented were more likely to prompt a psychologically competitive or cooperative mindset. *Hierarchical interdependence* was coded 1 when actors were higher in power or status relative to targets (e.g., actors were leaders or managers, or held resources valuable to the target), -1 when actors were lower than targets, and 0 when actors and targets were arguably equal on the hierarchy gradient. Studies were also coded for whether there was separation or sharedness in *social categorization* between actor and target. Specifically, targets who were explicitly noted as part of a distinct age, racial, ethnic, or gender category were considered to be in separate social groups from the actor (1), otherwise not (0). Interrater agreement for the coding of the psychological interdependence moderators was 94%.

Finally, we coded investigations for a few control variables. Studies were classified based on the context or population from which the participants were sampled (ongoing employees in organizations: 1 ; students or general adult population: 0). Because gender affects some of the outcomes we examined (e.g.,

poorer value capture outcomes for women in negotiations relative to men; Kennedy & Kray, 2015), we included the proportion of female participants in each sample as a covariate in our analyses. To control for the possibility that effect sizes are biased by publication status, we coded studies for whether they were published (1) or unpublished (0). Studies, their effect sizes, and our coding decisions can be found in Appendix A of the online supplemental materials.

Meta-Analytic Techniques

Each sample contributed at least one effect size to the meta-analysis for perspective taking or empathic concern. Although many investigations reported relationships involving both perspective taking and empathic concern relative to multiple outcomes, independence of the observations was always maintained. In other words, no more than one effect size obtained from each sample was included in a given main effect or moderation analysis. When two variables measured two dependent constructs for the same outcome domain, effect sizes were averaged (Harrison, Newman, & Roth, 2006). All effect sizes were converted to correlation coefficients (r) via procedures outlined by Lipsey and Wilson (2001). When information was insufficient for computing an effect size, we contacted authors to try to get the necessary data.

After effect sizes were computed, we adjusted observed effects for artifacts. Specifically, corrections were made to account for sampling error and unreliability in the measurement of independent and dependent constructs (Schmidt & Hunter, 2004). We chose to adjust for measurement reliability within each study rather than using artifact distributions because (a) the majority of investigations reported reliability data, (b) it is conceptually important to maintain differential levels of reliability across measures for each of the independent constructs and outcome domains, and (c) we wanted to allow for moderator analyses. When reliability data were not reported, we followed an imputation method whereby an average reliability coefficient was computed for measures within each independent construct or outcome domain and substituted these for missing values (e.g., Balkundi & Harrison, 2006; Hülshager, Anderson, & Salgado, 2009). No corrections were made for dichotomous predictor or criterion

measures. Appendix B of the online supplemental materials contains reliability information for the independent and dependent constructs.

We estimated the magnitude of the direct effects of perspective taking and empathic concern on the outcome domains using a random-effects model (Schmidt & Hunter, 2004). Population effects were estimated using correlations corrected for measurement unreliability and weighted by their sample-size and squared attenuation factor (Schmidt & Hunter, 2004, p. 149). Results are reported via 95% confidence intervals and 80% credibility intervals, and t tests of the differences between perspective taking and empathic concern meta-analytic effect sizes were computed for comparing their relative effects (Aguinis, Sturman, & Pierce, 2008; Neter, Wasserman, & Whitmore, 1988). Cochran's Q tests for heterogeneity were computed to determine the likelihood that more than one population effect existed for a particular relationship. Significant chi-square statistics for this test indicate potential moderators. Moderation of theoretical variables on the effects of perspective taking and empathic concern was modeled with a random/mixed-effects metaregression, where outcome domains and covariates were included as controls (van Houwelingen, Arends, & Stijnen, 2002).

Testing for Publication Bias

Although we included a number of unpublished effect sizes in our meta-analyses and controlled for publication status in our moderator analyses (Sterne & Egger, 2005), we generated funnel plots to partially explore the possibility of additional but missing unpublished effects (Sterne et al., 2011). Figure 2 depicts both perspective taking (Panel A) and empathic concern (Panel B) effect sizes by their inverse standard errors. In these plots, effect sizes with lower sampling errors (i.e., greater precision) generally cluster at the top, with effect sizes from less precise samples dispersed across the base of the funnel. When variance in the distribution of effect sizes is due to sampling error alone, the shape of the plot should be roughly symmetrical. In addition, the plots should (and do) center around a nonzero number when a population effect exists.

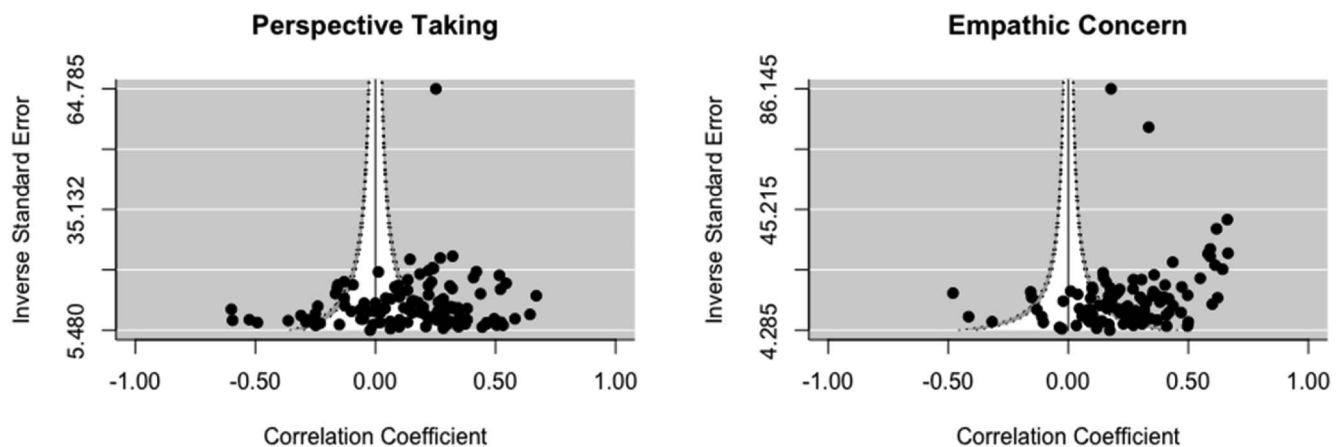


Figure 2. Funnel plots of corrected correlation coefficients by inverse standard error. Dark gray shading along the edge of the funnels represents a confidence interval of marginally significant results with p values of .05 to .10.

The plot for perspective taking appears roughly symmetrical, but the plot for empathic concern does not. In addition to this visual check, a statistical test can determine whether asymmetry in the pattern of data points is likely to exist (Egger, Davey Smith, Schneider, & Minder, 1997; Sterne & Egger, 2005). For perspective taking, Egger's regression test was nonsignificant ($z = -1.48$, $p = .14$), giving us reason to believe that no unpublished effect sizes are missing from our sample. Confirming our visual interpretation of asymmetry in the empathic concern plot, the test for this group of effect sizes was significant ($z = -3.14$, $p < .01$). Interestingly, however, the pattern is *not* consistent with asymmetry due to publication bias (missing studies in the lower left portion of the plot; Kepes, Banks, McDaniel, & Whetzel, 2012). We discovered that some of the larger field studies of empathic concern's effects tended to have smaller reliabilities, resulting in a cluster of data points being dragged upward and to the right upon correction for unreliability.² Thus, we concluded that it was the methodological features of these studies, and not publication bias, contributing to the unusual pattern of asymmetry observed in the empathic concern funnel plot.

Results

Perspective Taking, Empathic Concern, and Organizational Outcomes

Construct differentiation. We proposed in Hypothesis 1 that perspective taking and empathic concern would emerge as related but clearly separable constructs. Although there are no definitive cutoffs for determining whether a correlation between two variables reflects common versus distinct constructs, one precedent follows the pattern of Cohen's (1992) guidelines for evaluating effect sizes. That is, an intercorrelation of .50 and above (what Cohen considered a "large" effect size) has been interpreted in prior meta-analyses to mean that two variables share substantial commonality (e.g., Berry, Ones, & Sackett, 2007; Cole, Walter, Bedeian, & O'Boyle, 2012). Conversely, more modest intercorrelations have been viewed as evidence of distinct constructs (e.g., Berry, Lechhook, & Clark, 2012; Dalal, 2005).

The average corrected correlation between perspective taking and empathic concern across $k = 29$ samples was $\rho = .49$ ($n = 4,976$). This estimate approaches the .50 cutoff, but it also indicates that perspective taking and empathy share only 24% of their variance. Taking into account the previously discussed potential for construct contamination in our sample, we contend that this connection is moderate enough to support our first hypothesis.

Before presenting results relevant to the remaining hypotheses, it is also prudent to establish the independence of perspective taking and empathic concern from potentially overlapping constructs. Scholars have identified a number of individual differences that involve an other-oriented framing of one's social context at work. Specifically, meta-analytic summaries demonstrate that emotional intelligence (Joseph, Jin, Newman, & O'Boyle, 2015), self-monitoring (Day, Shleicher, Unckless, & Hiller, 2002), and agreeableness (Mount, Barrick, & Stewart, 1998) are important traits for navigating workplace relationships. Thus, in accord with the methods outlined above, we collected primary studies and meta-analyzed correlations between perspective taking, empathic concern, and these other-oriented traits.

The results of our construct differentiation checks are presented in Table 2. They demonstrate that neither perspective taking nor empathic concern has a "large" correlation of .50 or above (and neither shares more than 20% of its variance) with emotional intelligence, self-monitoring, or agreeableness. Based on these findings, we conclude that the establishment of construct differentiation clearly merits the additional testing of Hypotheses 2–14.

Actor support. Table 3 presents our meta-analytic findings regarding unique effects of perspective taking and empathic concern in the domains of actor contribution, actor-target joint performance, and target receptivity. In Hypothesis 2, we predicted that actor perspective taking would be positively related to supportive (a) attitudes, (b) intentions, and (c) behaviors toward targets. This hypothesis was partially supported. Perspective taking had similar-sized positive relationships to supportive attitudes ($\rho = .22$, $k = 54$, $n = 11,475$) and behaviors ($\rho = .15$, $k = 47$, $n = 7,026$) toward targets, but the confidence interval for the smaller set of studies connecting perspective taking and supportive intentions included zero ($\rho = .08$, $k = 14$, $n = 1,137$).

Empathic concern was positively related to actor supportive attitudes ($\rho = .31$, $k = 37$, $n = 8,916$), intentions ($\rho = .31$, $k = 12$, $n = 921$), and behaviors toward targets ($\rho = .22$, $k = 40$, $n = 13,534$), fully supporting Hypotheses 3a–3c. Likewise, Hypotheses 4a–4c were supported. The effects of empathic concern on actor (a) attitudes, (b) intentions, (c) behaviors were significantly stronger and more positive than for perspective taking, $t(89) = 2.43$, $p < .05$; $t(24) = 2.92$, $p < .01$; $t(85) = 2.35$, $p < .05$; respectively).

Actor-target joint performance. We proposed in Hypotheses 5a and 5b that perspective taking would be positively related to an actor's (a) value capture and (b) joint value creation between actor and target. The results support H5b but not H5a; perspective taking had a positive relation to value creation ($\rho = .17$, $k = 12$, $n = 1,273$) but an insignificant link to value capture ($\rho = .09$, $k = 13$, $n = 970$). Hypothesis 6 predicted that empathic concern would have a *negative* association with both (a) value capture and (b) joint value creation. Our data revealed that empathic concern did have a negative effect of $\rho = -.23$ on actor value capture ($k = 16$, $n = 1,415$), but not actor-target value creation ($\rho = .03$, $k = 10$, $n = 829$), providing support for Hypothesis 6a, but not 6b.

Target receptivity. Hypothesis 7, which proposed that perspective taking would have a positive effect on target receptive (a) attitudes and (b) behaviors, was partially supported. We observed a positive meta-analytic relationship with the target's attitudes ($\rho = .14$, $k = 8$, $n = 1,025$), but no relationship with the target's behavior ($\rho = -.01$, $k = 5$, $n = 737$). In contrast, the results strongly supported Hypotheses 8a and 8b. Empathic concern was positively related to targets' receptive attitudes ($\rho = .54$, $k = 7$, $n = 915$) and behaviors ($\rho = .18$, $k = 6$, $n = 1,574$). In line with these findings, Hypothesis 9, which proposed that empathic concern would have a stronger relationship than perspective taking to a target's receptive (a) attitudes and (b) behaviors, was thus supported, $t(13) = 6.11$, $p < .01$ and $t(9) = 2.12$, $p = .06$.

² In addition to this explanation, we would like to note that funnel plots of the uncorrected (rather than corrected) correlations, as well as plots with sample size (rather than inverse standard error) on the y axis take on more normal shapes (see Appendix C of the online supplemental materials).

Table 2

Mean and Estimated Associations Between Perspective Taking, Empathic Concern, and Trait-Based, Other-Oriented Constructs

Measure	Perspective taking								Empathic concern							
	<i>k</i>	<i>N</i>	$\bar{r}$	$\hat{\rho}$	σ_p^2	80% CrI	95% CI	Q_w	<i>k</i>	<i>N</i>	$\bar{r}$	$\hat{\rho}$	σ_p^2	80% CrI	95% CI	Q_w
Empathic concern	29	4976	.37	.49	.02	.30, .67	.42, .55	85.04**	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	—
Self-monitoring	7	2386	.14	.18	.12	-.27, .63	-.09, .45	306.34**	5	1716	.13	.17	.04	-.10, .44	-.02, .37	82.94**
Emotional intelligence	11	3653	.30	.38	.05	.09, .66	.24, .51	192.96**	15	5050	.28	.36	.02	.19, .53	.28, .43	113.58**
Agreeableness	10	4165	.20	.27	.02	.09, .44	.17, .36	93.77**	9	4057	.30	.42	.02	.23, .62	.32, .53	109.66**

Note. *k* = number of effect sizes; *N* = total sample size; $\bar{r}$ = average correlation; $\hat{\rho}$ = estimated population correlation; σ_p^2 = variance of the estimated population correlation; CrI = credibility interval; CI = confidence interval; Q_w = Cochran's Q test for heterogeneity.

***p* < .01.

Cochran's *Q* tests for heterogeneity were significant for almost every meta-analytic effect size investigated, with two exceptions in the less-studied domain of target receptivity. These results indicated the need to examine potential sources of heterogeneity in population effects, satisfying a premise for Hypotheses 10–14. Moreover, 80% credibility intervals for perspective taking effects revealed a consistently wide range of both positive and negative values, suggesting that some moderators may reverse the sign of perspective taking across the outcome domains. Similarly, credibility intervals around empathic concern effects reached from small to medium or large in size (according to Cohen's classification; Cohen, 1992) for four of the seven outcome categories, strongly suggesting contingent effects, as we proposed.

Moderation by Psychological Interdependence

Outcome interdependence. Table 4 presents the results of our moderator analyses using random/mixed-effects metaregression. Controlling for the outcome domain (e.g., actor support, jointly determined value capture and value creation, and target receptivity), as well as three covariates (research setting, proportion female participants, and publication status), we examined whether the proposed psychological interdependence moderators had significant accentuating or attenuating impacts on the effects of perspective taking (Panel 1) and empathic concern (Panel 2). In

Hypothesis 10, we proposed outcome interdependence would moderate the outflow of perspective taking, such that its effects would be attenuated when outcome interdependence was negative, and accentuated when outcome interdependence was positive. The results of the metaregression support this hypothesis ($b = .07, p < .05$).

Hierarchical interdependence (power asymmetry). We proposed that psychological interdependence between actor and target in the form of a hierarchy gradient would significantly boost the strength of perspective taking (H11) and empathic concern (H12) effects. Hypothesis 11 was supported. When actors had more power or status than targets, the effect of perspective taking was stronger ($b = .11, p < .05$; note that this impact was estimated with outcome interdependence already accounted for in the model). However, we did not find support for Hypothesis 12. The hierarchical position of the actor relative target had no discernible effect on the relationship between empathic concern and outcomes at work ($b = .05, ns$).

Social category interdependence. In Hypotheses 13 and 14, we predicted that actor-target differences breaching social categories would strengthen effects of perspective taking and weaken effects of empathic concern, respectively. We did not find support for either prediction. A social category difference between actor and target had no bearing on the strength of

Table 3

Mean and Estimated Variation in Effect Sizes for Perspective Taking and Empathic Concern

Outcome domains	Perspective taking								Empathic concern							
	<i>k</i>	<i>N</i>	$\bar{r}$	$\hat{\rho}$	σ_p^2	80% CrI	95% CI	Q_w	<i>k</i>	<i>N</i>	$\bar{r}$	$\hat{\rho}$	σ_p^2	80% CrI	95% CI	Q_w
Actor support																
Attitudes	54	11475	.19	.22	.03	.01, .43	.17, .27	263.58**	37	8916	.27	.31	.03	.10, .52	.25, .37	202.73**
Intent	14	1137	.08	.08	.04	-.17, .33	-.04, .20	51.24**	12	921	.25	.31	.04	.06, .55	.18, .44	33.93**
Behavior	47	7026	.14	.15	.03	-.06, .35	.10, .20	181.53**	40	13534	.18	.22	.01	.07, .37	.18, .26	156.40**
Actor-target joint performance																
Value capture	13	970	.09	.09	.04	-.16, .35	-.03, .22	46.05**	16	1415	-.21	-.23	.01	-.37, -.09	-.31, -.15	28.84**
Value creation	12	1273	.16	.17	.03	-.05, .28	.05, .28	43.51**	10	829	.03	.03	.07	-.32, .38	-.16, .21	62.54**
Target receptivity																
Attitudes	8	1025	.12	.14	.00	.08, .20	.06, .22	9.39	7	915	.44	.54	.03	.31, .77	.40, .69	23.66**
Behavior	5	737	-.02	-.01	.04	-.27, .25	-.21, .19	25.35**	6	1574	.16	.18	.00	.11, .25	.11, .25	9.34

Note. *k* = number of effect sizes; *N* = total sample size; $\bar{r}$ = average correlation; $\hat{\rho}$ = estimated population correlation; σ_p^2 = variance of the estimated population correlation; CrI = credibility interval; CI = confidence interval; Q_w = Cochran's Q test for heterogeneity.

***p* < .01.

Table 4
Meta-Regression Models for Moderators of Perspective Taking and Empathic Concern Effect Sizes

Measure	Perspective taking			Empathic concern		
	<i>b</i>	<i>SE_b</i>	<i>z</i>	<i>b</i>	<i>SE_b</i>	<i>z</i>
Constant	-.01	.01		.12	.07	
Methodological features						
Organizational setting	.06	.04	1.41	-.10	.04	-2.22*
Proportion female participants	.19	.11	1.78	.05	.10	.54
Published	.05	.05	1.14	.16	.05	3.26**
Outcome domains ^a						
Joint performance—Value capture	-.19	.08	-2.49*	-.03	.07	-.39
Joint performance—Value creation	.10	.09	1.12	-.40	.08	-4.77**
Target receptivity	-.02	.06	-.39	.07	.06	1.14
Psychological interdependence						
Outcome (-1, 0, 1)	.07	.03	2.40*	-.01	.03	-.20
Hierarchical (-1, 0, 1)	.11	.05	2.40*	.05	.04	1.20
Social category difference (0, 1)	-.01	.04	-.23	-.06	.06	-1.07

Note. For perspective taking, the number of independent effect sizes (*k*) is 117; for empathic concern *k* = 107. *b* = unstandardized regression coefficient; *SE_b* = standard error of the regression coefficient; *z* = associated significance test. In these analyses, the signs for Value Capture have been reversed so that negative correlations represent the effect of the independent construct on an actor *taking* from the target, in alignment with the meaning of negative correlations for the target in the other outcome categories.

^a Baseline group is Actor Support.

* *p* < .05. ** *p* < .01.

perspective taking's impacts (*b* = -.01, *ns*) or empathic concern's (*b* = -.06, *ns*).

Moderation by Covariates

The results revealed no moderating effect of samples' gender distribution for either construct. However, study context and publication status were associated with the potency of empathic concern. In particular, empathic concern effects were weaker when participants were sampled from employee populations in organizations (*b* = -.10, *p* < .05), and stronger in published versus unpublished studies (*b* = .16, *p* < .01), consistent with the funnel plots above.

Supplemental Analyses

Mediated effects? It is important to note that perspective taking has also been argued to impact actor contributions secondarily rather than primarily—that is, *through* empathic concern (e.g., Shih, Wang, Bucher, & Stotzer, 2009; Skorinko, Laurent, Bountress, Nyein, & Kuckuck, 2014). We do not contend that empathic concern never mediates the effects of perspective taking. Rather, we suggest that perspective taking retains a significant primary or unique effect when allowed to covary with empathic concern. To supplement the reported results, we therefore conducted a meta-analytic path analysis to determine the unique impacts of perspective taking and empathic concern, as well as their shared variance when accounting for these associations.

To determine the extent to which perspective taking effects change when empathic concern is included in the model, we conducted meta-analytic path analyses with data from a subset of investigations that measured the effects of both constructs on actor support (actor-target joint performance and target receptivity studies that measured both constructs were too few for separate path

analyses). Among these 25 investigations, with *N* = 2807, the meta-analytic effect of perspective taking on actor support was *ρ* = .25, the impact of empathic concern on actor support was *ρ* = .30, and perspective taking and empathic concern had an association of *ρ* = .49.

Using these values as our input correlation matrix, we first examined a model including both the direct path of perspective taking to actor support as well as its indirect path through empathic concern. When accounting for indirect (mediated) effects, perspective taking retained a significant direct impact on actor support (*z* = 11.46, *p* < .01), thus ruling out a model in which the impacts of perspective taking are fully mediated by empathic concern. To test for partial mediation, we compared this saturated model to one in which the indirect paths (from perspective taking to empathic concern and empathic concern to actor support) were set to zero. A comparison of these two models revealed that the indirect pathway of perspective taking through empathic concern was also significant ($\chi^2 = 799.57$, *df* = 2, *p* < .01). Thus, we conclude that although the effect of perspective taking may be mediated partially by empathic concern, it also directly impacts actor support for the target.

Contingencies of perspective taking in joint performance?

Despite the conclusions of qualitative reviews that perspective taking provides strategic advantages for both distributive and integrative negotiation outcomes, we did not find strong support for the former. As a result, we wondered whether researchers have often found positive effects of perspective taking on value capture *because* their study contexts tend to involve heightened competitiveness between the actor and target. In other words, is our null main (overall) effect of perspective taking on value capture the result of including studies that cover the full range of competitive (negative outcome-interdependent) to cooperative (positive outcome-interdependent) contingencies?

To further explore the nature of this unexpected finding, we conducted two additional random/mixed-effects metaregressions: one on the effects of perspective taking on value capture, and the other on the effects of perspective taking on value creation, with both including outcome interdependence as the single moderator.³ The results supported our suspicion of perspective taking's contingent effects on value capture. As outcome interdependence changed from negative to positive, the effects of perspective taking on value capture were significantly weakened (i.e., perspective taking resulted in much greater value capture when outcome interdependence was negative; $b = -.19, p < .01$). The effects of perspective taking on value creation were similarly contingent on outcome interdependence, with perspective taking having a stronger effect on value creation when outcome interdependence was negative. This implies that competitive contexts lead perspective-taking actors to behave more strategically with regards to both themselves and, when possible, their partner.

Discussion

See Their Side or Feel Their Pain?

When navigating complex social relationships with coworkers, seeing their side (perspective taking) and feeling their pain (empathic concern) are each uniquely useful tools. First, our results suggest that perspective taking and empathy are empirically separable constructs, with less than 25% shared variance between them. Second, their distinct patterns of effects, in both the sizes of their impact across outcomes and in their contingencies guided by psychological interdependence, flow from different underlying mechanisms. Regardless of the nature of psychological interdependence between actor and target, empathic concern drives greater actor support through its *target-centric* mechanism than does perspective taking, which perceives targets' minds through *actor-centric* anchoring.

However, perspective taking becomes an asset, whereas empathic concern is a liability, for determining personal or joint (actor-target) performance, particularly as outcome interdependence moves from positive to negative. This is because perspective taking uniquely involves actors *ascribing goals and intentions* to targets. Importantly, perspective taking's *dual focus of attention* to both self- and other-interests can foster greater personal success under conditions of negative outcome interdependence, but heightened perceptions of competition with the target may also lead the same actors to engage in advantage-taking, or unnecessarily undermining their interaction partners (Duffy et al., 2002; Epley et al., 2006).

Our results also revealed opposing contingencies for perspective taking and empathic concern when considering hierarchical forms of interdependencies between actor and target. A positive hierarchy gradient (when actors are higher relative to targets) bolstered the effects of perspective taking, but not empathic concern. Thus, it may be particularly helpful to have a supervisor who takes the perspective of his or her subordinates (Williams, 2016), but less vital that perspective taking looks *upward* on the hierarchy gradient from subordinate to supervisor. We were surprised to find that the advantages of empathic concern were not impacted by a hierarchy gradient between actor and target. It is perhaps the case that power diminishes an actor's attention to the relative vulnera-

bility of the target because of a heightened focus on their own goals and self-interest (Galinsky, Magee, Gruenfeld, Whitson, & Liljenquist, 2008).

Our arguments regarding the effects of social category interdependence on perspective taking and empathic concern effects were not supported. A potential explanation for the null finding is a curvilinear moderating effect. Although some social dissimilarity may amplify the effects of perspective taking in the way we initially hypothesized, psychological distances beyond a certain degree may be too difficult to bridge—potentially making dissimilarity *more* salient to the actor (ex., Skorinko & Sinclair, 2013; Tarrant, Calitri, & Weston, 2012). Unfortunately, we were not able to code for these nuances in our data, as group membership is treated as a binary variable, not as continuous distance, in original studies. Alternatively, we might have been too inclusive with what we coded as social category interdependence.⁴ As scholars have noted, differences alone may not be enough to trigger psychological interdependence between actor and target (Williams, 2001). It was not always clear in primary studies whether participants *perceived* interdependencies stemming from social category similarities or differences, and our attempts to recode them according to this stricter criterion did not change results. We suggest that future research on the effects of perspective taking and empathy in diversity outcomes prioritize this issue of precision in operationalizing social category interdependence.

It is equally, if not more informative, to consider our results from the viewpoint of the partner or target. Would we prefer those with whom we work and interact in organizations to see our side or to feel our pain? Among the studies examining target receptivity, our meta-analytic results strongly indicate that working with empathic versus perspective-taking others results in more positive experiences overall. Although meta-analysis cannot be used to test for mediation directly, our results suggest that targets may benefit as a function of actors' consistent support, while perspective taking might lead to support *or* resistance and selfishness (Chiaburu & Harrison, 2008), depending on the context.

Digging Deeper into Perspective Taking and Empathic Concern as Separate Constructs

The empirical patterns we observed, strongly distinguishing perspective taking and empathic concern, align with distinct underlying mechanisms. Perspective taking appears to mirror and magnify the nature of outcome interdependence between actor and target (Pierce et al., 2013). It strengthens social bonds when target mindsets are perceived as cooperative, and heightens opposition when they are perceived as competitive. Alternatively, empathic concern has a largely affective mechanism. It works by amplifying the target's interests, regardless of how they may impact the actor. Thus, it is important that other-oriented processes are matched to the particular task or desired outcome according to these mechanisms (Gilin et al., 2013).

³ We were unable to control for the full range of covariates included in the analyses of the main sample because (a) there were too few that had a hierarchy or social dissimilarity component and (b) there was not enough power to include the remainder of the coded covariates.

⁴ We thank an anonymous reviewer for bringing this insight to our attention.

The results of the supplemental meta-analytic path analysis further support our proposed model. First, we ruled out a model in which perspective taking's effects on actor support are fully mediated by empathic concern. Moreover, it is impossible for the positive effects of perspective taking on (actor-target) jointly determined performance to be explained by empathic concern, because the latter has negative or null effects on the same type of outcome. These observations lead us to conclude that although perspective taking may at times impact task outcomes through an affective mechanism (as others have suggested), it can also stand alone.

Despite evidence pushing for the separation of perspective taking and empathic concern, some scholars have continued to blend the two. As we have already discussed, measures and manipulations that include the actor's attention to both cognitive and affective components of the target's experiences risk construct contamination and imprecise estimation of their independent impacts. To illustrate that risk, we conducted post hoc meta-analyses with the studies that "blended" or combined perspective taking and empathic concern into a singular predictor (see Coding Schemes section for more information). As expected, the magnitude of estimated population effects for the mixed construct concern often fell in between those of the more "purely" operationalized constructs ($\rho = .15$, $k = 7$, $N = 241$ for the blended construct and effects on actor supportive intentions; $\rho = .19$, $k = 11$, $N = 1404$ for actor supportive behavior; and $\rho = .09$, $k = 5$, $N = 704$ for target receptivity). Because most of these studies purported to examine impacts of perspective taking, our meta-analytic results represent the relatively lower (but still significantly positive) edge of population effects of an uncontaminated perspective taking construct. Neglecting to empirically differentiate perspective taking and empathic concern—lumping rather than splitting—will further contribute to imprecise estimates of their impacts (Newman, Harrison, Carpenter, & Rariden, 2016).

We further contend that moving forward, it will be helpful to characterize these two processes as separate forms of *interpersonal learning*. Both perspective taking and empathic concern are strategies for uncovering information about the target that is "under the surface," and they have distinct, but predictable sets of biases. Future research might consider examining perspective taking and empathic concern in conjunction with other forms of interpersonal learning that similarly are used to infer targets' goals, values, and expectations, but are also vulnerable to biased conclusions. Such channels of interpersonal learning may include stereotyping, behavioral attributions, and emotion perception, to name a few.

Practical Implications

Our model, and the decades of evidence that cumulatively support it, have a number of practical implications for managers and employees engaged in interdependent work. Although actors may vary in how much they tend to engage in perspective taking and empathic concern, both are amenable to intervention (Zaki, 2014). When considering potential interventions for building strong social bonds of trust, support, and cooperation among employees in an organization, our results strongly favor training in affectively—rather than cognitively driven orientations toward others. As one exception, however, our model also indicates that perspective taking should be considered an asset, and empathic

concern, a liability, when developing skills for negotiations or mixed motive interactions.

Engaging in perspective taking may be particularly useful for managers as they relate to their employees. We found that relational and performance consequences were more strongly associated with downward, rather than lateral or upward perspective taking. Moreover, power has been shown to inhibit perspective taking (Galinsky et al., 2006), so successfully fostering this skill in leaders and managers is likely to lead to significant improvements as they relate to others. In addition, managers who engage in perspective taking may carry out decisions with greater procedural and distributive justice. Our results suggest that when deciding how to distribute valued resources among employees or units, perspective taking actors are more likely to do so fairly, whereas empathic concern for one party may result in unjust outcomes for others.

Our results also have practical implications for potential targets of perspective taking and empathic concern. Prior research has shown that appealing to the sympathies of a counterpart in tasks with negative outcome interdependence can result in better distributive outcomes for the target (Shirako, Kilduff, & Kray, 2015). Assuming that targets could successfully appeal to an actor's perspective taking or empathic concern in other contexts or situations, our model strongly implies that targets should choose empathy. Even under contingencies that strengthen the positive effects of perspective taking or weaken the positive effects of empathic concern, targets almost always benefit more when interacting with empathic coworkers or managers. One exception to this rule occurs when collaborating on tasks with jointly determined outputs, such as decision making or creative problem solving; then, perspective taking creates more value.

Limitations and Future Directions

As with all meta-analyses, there are limitations to our conclusions that are part of the paradigm itself. First, some of our findings must be interpreted with caution until even further evidence accumulates. To that end, we suggest that future research efforts focus on the outcome domain with the fewest investigations—those examining the receptivity of task partners (targets) themselves. It is important to understand *when* an actor's efforts at perspective taking or empathic concern are perceived by targets, as well as *how* they are received. For example, perspective taking may be met with appreciation and returned with cooperation in some circumstances, but met with distrust and returned with withdrawal in others (Chiaburu & Harrison, 2008). Increasing the number of studies in these outcome domains would also allow us to explore whether patterns of contingencies hold across the type of outcome examined (e.g., Does a hierarchy gradient moderate the effect of actor perspective taking on target receptivity to the same extent that it moderates perspective taking's effect on actor supportive behaviors?).

Now that the basic psychological relationships between perspective taking, empathic concern, and actors' attitudes and behaviors have been more firmly established, we also suggest addressing a third limitation of relatively less investigation in longer-term, ongoing relationships, teams, and firms. Conducting more time-sensitive research in organizational settings will reveal additional task and context-specific outcomes, as well as boundary conditions that may amplify, suppress, or even reverse the effects of these constructs in

dynamic, multifaceted work contexts. For example, does perspective taking increase the value of suggestions offered up by employees for organizational or job role improvements (i.e., voice; Howell, Harrison, Burris, & Detert, 2015)? Can empathic concern lead to positively reinforcing cycles of compassion and care within organizations, as well as across organizational boundaries (Dutton et al., 2014)?

In another specific realm, although some have shown prejudice-reducing (attitude-improving) effects of perspective taking, our cumulative results paint a less-than-rosy picture of its potential to overcome social categorization or to ease tensions of demographic diversity at work. For perspective taking to work in ways that benefit parties on each side of a diversity divide, our results suggest that actors would need convincing that their outcomes were aligned *with*, rather than aligned *against*, their perceptual target's—opposite of much of the rhetoric surrounding demographically charged workforce debates (Harrison, Kravitz, Mayer, Leslie, & Lev-Arey, 2006; Shteynberg, Leslie, Knight, & Mayer, 2011). Somewhat more optimistically, our results suggest that the impacts of empathic concern are consistently positive whether working with socially similar or dissimilar others, and whether outcomes are aligned or misaligned. In other words, empathic concern does not lose potency based on social dissimilarity or outcome interdependence between actor and target, so it may be a more promising avenue than perspective taking for addressing diversity-driven tensions and conflicts.

Collecting more fine-grained diversity data would also allow us to better understand the contingent effects of social category interdependence. For example, our suggestion that social differences or dissimilarity may have a curvilinear moderating influence on perspective taking (strengthening its effects up to a moderate point, but reducing them thereafter) may be tested by taking into account a number of surface and deep-level differences. It is possible that perspective taking may have a stronger positive effect when actor and target are separated by deep-level cognitive or psychological differences, such as orientations to time (Mohammed & Harrison, 2013); but weaker benefits when separations are visible, such as with race or gender.

Fourth, our results deal with individual and dyadic-level outcomes. It is important to expand our understanding of the roles played by perspective taking and empathic concern in improving or impeding *group-level* processes and outputs. The few extant studies have produced conflicting results. For example, some have found that perspective taking plays a role in improving team creativity (Hoever et al., 2012), but others have found that perspective taking in teams can have detrimental effects on performance (Schouten, Bechtoldt, & Beersma, 2017). Future group-level research is needed to untangle these complex effects.

Turning to even less explored directions, scholars have identified the potentially “perverse” effects of perspective taking (Ku et al., 2015), but some have begun to explore the “dark side” of empathic concern as well. For example, psychologists have found that empathy for a target in distress can lead to aggression directed toward the target's competitor, even when the competitor is clearly *not* responsible for the target's suffering (Buffone & Poulin, 2014). Empathic concern may also prompt good-intended intervention when it is not needed (Batson, 2012), such as when new hires, or ongoing employees tasked with new roles, need to develop a sense of autonomy and self-sufficiency. Empathy might also have harmful effects on the actor him- or herself. For example, empathizers who are frequently sought out as “emotion helpers” in the workplace may feel dissatisfaction due

to a lack of reciprocity in those social ties (Toegel, Kilduff, & Anand, 2013). Employees in roles that require frequent expressions of empathic concern could at times suffer from compassion fatigue or burnout (Dutton et al., 2014).

Finally, and emphatically, we suggest future investigations that examine the *compound or interactive effects of engaging in perspective taking and empathic concern*. As parts of two different—mainly cognitive or mainly affective—mechanisms, they can and do occur simultaneously in a variety of configurations. Now that their distinction and their differential contingencies have been firmly established, it is important to understand the nature of the interplay between these two.

When *both* perspective taking and empathic concern are high, we might expect an amplification of positive effects on actor support, as the former identifies the target's specific needs and likely response, while the latter provides motivation to act. However, high empathic concern with low perspective taking could make actors more likely to help in ways that are quick fixes to the target's problem, but neglect to consider long term solutions for the underlying issue. Alternatively, high perspective taking and low empathic concern for targets who are suffering, such as recipients of medical care and their families, may lead to an actor's cognitive understanding of what has gone wrong, but deprive targets of more immediate emotional needs for compassion in times of hardship (Barsade & O'Neill, 2014). Similarly, scholars of intimate relationships have found that understanding a partner's thoughts and feelings (i.e., perspective taking) can be unhelpful or even harmful when empathic concern is low (Winczewski, Bowen, & Collins, 2016). In jointly determined outcomes, might perspective taking lead to even greater value capture for the actor when high empathic concern expressed for the target leads to misguided trust in the actor's pure intentions? These will be important questions for future investigations to address.

Conclusion

This meta-analytic summary of more than 100 studies and more than 300 effect sizes brings us to a much stronger and sharper understanding of how employees might successfully address the social complexities of working with others. First, we found that perspective taking and empathic concern are both powerful tools for extending support to others, but that empathy has a consistently stronger impact than perspective taking on strengthening social bonds. On the other hand, perspective taking allows actors to attain resource-focused goals in strategic interactions, where emotional engagement through empathic concern can create harmful interference. Using this information, organizations should be able to structure employees' task engagement in such a way that primes empathic concern where social bonds are needed, but perspective taking where strategically managing resources is the primary aim.

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